

## Review

# Feeling understood and appreciated in relationships: Where do these perceptions come from and why do they matter?

Amie M. Gordon and Emily Diamond

**Abstract**

Perceptions of romantic partners (even inaccurate perceptions) are important determinants of initial liking and long-term relationship satisfaction. In the current article, we consider the role of perceptions in romantic relationships through the lens of felt understanding and appreciation. We first examine where perceptions of feeling understood and appreciated come from, considering partner, self, and dyadic influences. We then examine how feeling understood and appreciated shape relationship quality, focusing on these perceptions as buffers of negative relationship experiences and mechanisms through which couples can create positive upward cycles of responsiveness and appreciation. Finally, we theorize about the unique *dyadic* experience of feeling understood and appreciated, positing that moments of mutual understanding and appreciation play a critical role in increasing social connection.

**Addresses**

University of Michigan, MI, USA

Corresponding author: Gordon, Amie M. ([amiemg@umich.edu](mailto:amiemg@umich.edu))

**Current Opinion in Psychology** 2023, **53**:101687

This review comes from a themed issue on **Listening & Responsiveness (2024)**

Edited by **Harry Reis** and **Guy Itzhakov**

For complete overview about the section, refer [Listening & Responsiveness \(2024\)](#)

Available online 10 August 2023

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2023.101687>

2352-250X/© 2023 Elsevier Ltd. All rights reserved.

**Keywords**

Responsiveness, Perceived understanding, Appreciation, Romantic, Relationship quality.

In romantic relationships, people's perceptions of their partner (even inaccurate perceptions) are important determinants of initial liking and long-term relationship satisfaction [1,2]. For example, it is more important for people to perceive their romantic partners as responsive than it is for their partner to actually be responsive [3]. Likewise, feeling understood by one's partner can be a stronger predictor of relationship quality than the partner's actual knowledge [4–6].

In the current article, we consider the role of perceptions in romantic relationships through the lens of felt understanding and appreciation, two foundational building blocks of responsiveness, intimacy, connection, and relationship quality [3,7]. We first examine where perceptions of feeling understood and appreciated come from. We then examine how feeling understood and appreciated shape relationship quality. Finally, we theorize about the unique *dyadic* experience of feeling understood and appreciated. Overall, we aim to bring together the latest literature to form a comprehensive understanding of the importance of feeling understood and appreciated and the role these perceptions play in the maintenance of high-quality relationships.

## Where do perceptions of feeling understood and appreciated come from?

People's feelings of being understood and appreciated by their romantic partners come from many sources, including one's partner, oneself, and shared dyadic experiences. These perceptions may be driven by how partners act and perceive one another *generally* as well as their behaviors, thoughts, and emotions in *specific moments* together [7].

### Partner influences

In general, people feel appreciated by partners who are responsive and engage in relationship maintenance behaviors [8], such as those who attempt to resolve conflict or encourage their partners to share their feelings [9]. People are also likely to feel appreciated by partners who are attentive to their behaviors, such as those who are active listeners [10] and who perceive and acknowledge a sacrifice [11,12]. People may also feel more understood by partners who are more similar to them [13,14]. During specific social interactions, people are more likely to feel understood and appreciated by partners who have thoughtful, detailed responses [5] or who are highly expressive [15]. Specific listening behaviors may also play an important role in fostering felt understanding and appreciation. Recent theorizing about listening and responsiveness suggests that partners can demonstrate their attention and comprehension during conversations by engaging in behaviors such as asking follow-up questions, validating the speaker, maintaining eye contact, and nodding [16]. In turn,

these responsive listening behaviors likely promote feeling understood and appreciated.

### Self influences

Although felt understanding and appreciation reflect people's perceptions of how their partner feels about them, a large part of feeling understood and appreciated likely stems from people's own behaviors, thoughts, and emotions. For example, people can behave in ways that promote understanding and appreciation in their partner through reciprocity, such as being more responsive, appreciative, and understanding themselves, which is likely to prompt their partner to be responsive, appreciative, and understanding in turn [8]. People may also feel understood and appreciated during conversations with their partner if they are non-defensive [17]. Of course, feeling understood and appreciated may also reduce defensiveness [18,19].

People's beliefs about themselves also shape their perceptions through projection. Indeed, there is evidence that people project their own levels of responsiveness onto their partners [20]. Thus, it is likely that the extent to which people feel understood and appreciated is influenced by how understanding and appreciative they view themselves to be. People's perceptions can also be influenced by other feelings and experiences: individuals who are more satisfied in their relationships tend to assume they are understood, even during conflict [21,22]. In addition, people who are more depressed tend to perceive their partners as less able to understand their thoughts and feelings [23], though this does not appear to be entirely due to motivated cognition—there is evidence their partners actually are less understanding.

Motivation to be understood and appreciated also matters, as it affects how people think, feel, and behave. People often want to feel understood, especially when their self-views are important to them [24] and culturally valued [25]. People who are motivated to be understood and appreciated by their partners may be more likely to engage in behaviors that promote their partner's understanding and appreciation, such as openly communicating their feelings and beliefs to their partner or doing a kind gesture. However, motivation may also bias one's perceptions. People who want to feel understood and appreciated by their partners, such as those who have a strong desire to feel accepted for who they are [19], may arrive at the desired conclusion that they are understood and appreciated even in the absence of any confirmatory evidence [5].

### Dyadic influences

Importantly, felt understanding and appreciation are dyadic processes and thus are shaped by shared experiences. Ample research demonstrates that romantic

partners synchronize in various ways, including in their thoughts (e.g., generalized shared reality) [26] and emotions (e.g., positivity resonance and co-experienced affect) [27,28]. However, the literature on synchrony is predominantly separate from the literature on responsiveness, understanding, and appreciation [29]. We argue that synchronous moments—moments in which partners converge in their thoughts and emotions—represent reciprocal understanding between partners. In moments of synchrony, *both* partners are likely to feel understood and appreciated due to a shared understanding of how each person—and the world—works. Other synchronous processes such as physiological and neural synchrony may also implicitly enhance understanding (and thus feeling understood). Because thoughts and feelings are often embodied [30], physiological synchrony and nonverbal mimicry may help people better understand how their partner is thinking and feeling. For example, if both partners have elevated blood pressure and heart rates during an interaction together and are sharing expressions of stress, these shared experiences may make it easier for them to understand each other. Of course, feeling understood and appreciated may promote enhanced synchrony, as well. In one study, couples had greater cortisol synchrony when they reported feeling understood and appreciated by their partner in the past several hours [31].

### How do perceptions of feeling understood and appreciated shape relationship quality?

Researchers are increasingly providing evidence that perceptions of feeling understood and appreciated play an important role in shaping the quality of relationships. Two key ways in which these perceptions appear to play a role are through their ability to act as (1) buffers during negative relationship experiences and (2) mechanisms to promote cycles of responsiveness and appreciation.

*Feeling understood and appreciated as buffers during negative relationship experiences* Perceptions of feeling understood and appreciated may act as buffers because they help promote positive sentiment override, in which people view their partner and their relationship through a positive lens [32]. If people feel that their partner understands and appreciates them, this feeling of being known and valued may help people have a more positive view of their partner and consequently encourage them to engage in more prosocial behaviors during negative relationship experiences, such as giving their partner the benefit of the doubt and responding more positively to partner transgressions. People may also be more likely to disclose their own difficult feelings and experiences with their partner when they feel understood and appreciated. In one study of adolescents and parents, adolescents anticipated greater well-being—and a greater intention to self-disclose in the future—when imagining disclosing a transgression and feelings of hurt

to a parent who listened well [33]. Feeling understood and appreciated may also help people be more open to listening to partners who challenge them to think differently (e.g., to reappraise a problem) [34]. In line with this theorizing, people who feel more understood [35] and appreciated [36,37] by their partners tend to maintain higher levels of relationship quality in the face of relationship conflict compared to those who feel less understood and appreciated. In fact, in one laboratory study, people who felt more understood during a conflict conversation with their partner actually felt *more* satisfied after the conversation than when they first arrived in the lab [35]. Feeling appreciated has also been shown to buffer against the negative effects of other relationship stressors, such as financial strain [37] and unequal division of labor [38].

Feeling understood and appreciated may also act as a buffer for relationship insecurities. Expressions of gratitude from a partner have been shown to help buffer against the negative effects of attachment insecurities, particularly attachment avoidance [39]. Critically, it is people's *perceptions* of their partner's gratitude expressions that drive these effects. One reason why these perceptions may be buffering is because they increase one's sense of security within the relationship [40]. In one longitudinal study, people were less anxiously attached in the moment and over the following year when they perceived more gratitude from their partner [41].

### Perceptions of feeling understood and appreciated as mechanisms to promote cycles of responsiveness and appreciation

Gordon and colleagues [8] posited, and found evidence for, a positive cycle in which feeling appreciated by a partner promotes appreciation for one's partner—after all, a partner who values you (and engages in behaviors that convey this) is a partner worth appreciating. In

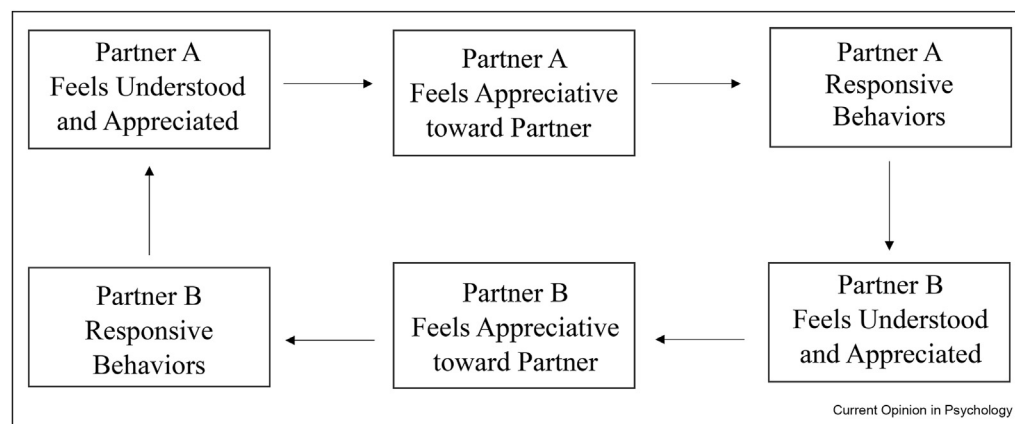
turn, this appreciation was shown to prompt relationship maintenance behaviors that help people hold onto their relationships, such as being thoughtful and responsive in daily life (see also [42]). Completing the cycle, people felt more appreciated by partners who engage in these relationship maintenance behaviors. In this way, felt understanding and appreciation may help catalyze positive cycles of responsive behaviors and appreciation (see Figure 1). For example, when people expect to be understood during a conflict conversation with their partner, they engage in more positive communication behavior [22].

### Dyadic experience of feeling understood and appreciated

Although research has predominantly focused on individual experiences of feeling understood and appreciated in relationships, these perceptions are inherently dyadic. Earlier we proposed that moments of synchrony—that is, shared thoughts, emotions, behaviors, and physiological responses—may promote feeling understood and appreciated. In this final section, we further consider the role of these shared moments, proposing that dyadic experiences in which both partners simultaneously convey understanding and appreciation *to* their partner and feel understood and appreciated *by* their partner may play an especially important role in relationship formation and maintenance, serving as a social glue that brings and keeps partners together.

Empirical research has demonstrated a clear link between shared thoughts and emotions and interpersonal closeness. Generalized shared reality (i.e., sharing a set of feelings, beliefs, or concerns with another person about the world in general) is a key predictor of initial connection and ongoing relationship satisfaction [26]. The link between shared thoughts and connection has also been found on the neural level: friends show similar neural responses when viewing audiovisual movies [43]

Figure 1



Perceptions of feeling understood and appreciated may help catalyze positive cycles of responsive behaviors, appreciation, and understanding.

and couples who synchronize their neural responses when viewing movies about married life tend to have greater marital satisfaction [44]. Similarly, shared emotional responses, such as feeling positive at the same time or laughing together, foster social connection [45] and are an integral component of high-quality relationships [28,46].

We propose that mutual understanding and appreciation is a key mechanism linking shared thoughts and emotions to high-quality social connection. That is, shared thoughts and emotions may be especially important in facilitating and maintaining social bonds precisely *because* of a mutual sense of understanding and appreciation. When two people say the same thought at the same time or laugh at the same joke, each person not only expresses their understanding of the other person (i.e., “I see that you think this is funny”) but also expresses their agreement (i.e., “I, too, think this is funny”), signaling their similarity. These shared experiences may also signal good listening, as it means that each person has heard and understood what the other person is saying. Consequently, both partners may feel that the other person “gets” them and that they are on the same wavelength or in sync, which are common lay accounts of high-quality connection [26].

Research on the dyadic experience of feeling understood and appreciated is an important avenue for future research. There is some evidence that people are most satisfied in their relationships when both partners are grateful [47] and the dyadic model of gratitude suggests that one appreciative partner should promote appreciation in the other partner, creating more moments of shared appreciation and understanding [8,48]. But many questions related to the experience of mutual understanding and appreciation—specifically at the momentary level—remain unanswered. For example, work is needed to examine whether mutual understanding and appreciation are key features of feeling in sync and connected to one’s partner—both within specific conversations and over time. Investigating the psychological and physiological signatures of mutual understanding and appreciation is another fruitful area for future work, as is delineating the specific factors that promote versus hinder mutual understanding and appreciation.

### Other avenues for future research

We have focused broadly on feeling understood and appreciated as two important components of perceived responsiveness, intimacy, and connection. We find in our own work that feeling understood and feeling appreciated are highly correlated within and between individuals and expect that they share many antecedents and consequences. For example, having a partner who is a good listener would likely heighten one’s felt

understanding and good listening might also indicate a partner who is caring and appreciative, as they are willing to take the time to listen well. Although these two perceptions often co-occur, there may also be times when people feel understood but not appreciated (“my partner sees me clearly but doesn’t value what they see”) or appreciated but not understood (“my partner values me but what they value isn’t the real me”). Thus, research is needed to identify shared and unique roles of feeling understood and feeling appreciated.

While we have focused here on the importance of feeling understood and appreciated, other work has focused on *being* understanding and appreciative. Integrating these two literature, one interesting avenue for future research is exploring when a person’s actual understanding and appreciation leads their partner to feel understood and appreciated, and when it does not. For example, are signals of understanding and appreciation less likely to be perceived by a partner when they are tired, sick, or overwhelmed?

Finally, although we have focused on perceived understanding and appreciation in the context of romantic relationships, we anticipate that feeling understood and appreciated would operate similarly in other types of relationships, such as parent-child relationships or relationships in the workplace. Indeed, research on listening in the workplace has similarly found evidence of dyadic effects of listening between team members [49].

### Conclusion

Existing research suggests that gratitude helps us find and bond to responsive partners and form moments of high-quality connection [42]. We suggest that the other side of that emotion—the *perception* of being appreciated—along with the perception of being understood, are additional important components of connection. Moments in which both partners feel understood and appreciated could play a crucial role throughout relationships, buffering against negative relationship experiences and promoting cycles of responsiveness and appreciation that bond partners to each other long-term.

### Authors Contribution

Both Amie Gordon and Emily Diamond contributed to conceptualization as well as writing the original draft, reviewing, and editing the paper.

### Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.



## Data availability

No data was used for the research described in the article.

## References

Papers of particular interest, published within the period of review, have been highlighted as:

- \* of special interest
- \*\* of outstanding interest

1. Gadassi R, Bar-Nahum LE, Newhouse S, Anderson R, Heiman JR, Rafaeli E, et al.: **Perceived partner responsiveness mediates the association between sexual and marital satisfaction: a daily diary study in newlywed couples.** *Arch Sex Behav* 2016, **45**:109–120, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10508-014-0448-2>.
2. Tidwell ND, Eastwick PW, Finkel EJ: **Perceived, not actual, similarity predicts initial attraction in a live romantic context: evidence from the speed-dating paradigm.** *Pers Relat* 2013, **20**:199–215, <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1475-6811.2012.01405.x>.
3. Reis HT, Clark MS, Holmes J: *Perceived partner responsiveness as an organizing construct in the study of intimacy and closeness.* 2004. <https://www.taylorfrancis.com/proxy.lib.umich.edu/chapters/edit/10.4324/9781410610010-19/perceived-partner-responsiveness-organizing-construct-study-intimacy-closeness-harry-reis-margaret-clark-john-holmes>. Accessed 26 June 2023.
4. Pollmann MMH, Finkenauer C: **Investigating the role of two types of understanding in relationship well-being: understanding is more important than knowledge.** *Pers Soc Psychol Bull* 2009, **35**:1512–1527, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167209342754>.  
Shows that feeling understood is a stronger predictor of relationship well-being than a partner's actual knowledge.
5. Reis HT, Lemay Jr EP, Finkenauer C: **Toward understanding understanding: the importance of feeling understood in relationships.** *Social and Personality Psychology Compass* 2017, **11**, e12308, <https://doi.org/10.1111/spc3.12308>.  
Provides a comprehensive conceptual framework for understanding the role of perceived understanding in relationships.
6. Hinnekens C, Stas L, Gistelincx F, Verhofstadt LL: **"I think you understand me." Studying the associations between actual, assumed, and perceived understanding within couples.** *Eur J Soc Psychol* 2020, **50**:46–60, <https://doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.2614>.
7. Reis HT, Shaver P, others: **Intimacy as an interpersonal process.** *Handbook of Personal Relationships* 1988:367–389.
8. Gordon AM, Impett EA, Kogan A, Oveis C, Keltner D: **To have and to hold: gratitude promotes relationship maintenance in intimate bonds.** *J Pers Soc Psychol* 2012, **103**:257–274, <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0028723>.  
Proposes the dyadic model of gratitude in which feeling appreciated promotes one's own appreciation, which in turn promotes responsive behaviors, which promote one's partner's feelings of being appreciated.
9. Kubacka KE, Finkenauer C, Rusbult CE, Keijsers L: **Maintaining close relationships: gratitude as a motivator and a detector of maintenance behavior.** *Pers Soc Psychol Bull* 2011, **37**:1362–1375, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167211412196>.
10. Kluger AN, Itzchakov G: **The power of listening at work.** *Annual Review of Organizational Psychology and Organizational Behavior* 2022, **9**:121–146, <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-orgpsych-012420-091013>.
11. Visserman ML, Impett EA, Righetti F, Muise A, Keltner D, Van Lange PAM: **To "see" is to feel grateful? A quasi-signal detection analysis of romantic partners' sacrifices.** *Soc Psychol Personal Sci* 2019, **10**:317–325, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1948550618757599>.
12. Zoppolat G, Visserman ML, Righetti F: **A nice surprise: sacrifice expectations and partner appreciation in romantic relationships.** *J Soc Pers Relat* 2020, **37**:450–466, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0265407519867145>.
13. Murray SL, Holmes JG, Bellavia G, Griffin DW, Dolderman D: **Kindred spirits? The benefits of egocentrism in close relationships.** *J Pers Soc Psychol* 2002, **82**:563–581, <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.82.4.563>.
14. Sels L, Ruan Y, Kuppens P, Ceulemans E, Reis H: **Actual and perceived emotional similarity in couples' daily lives.** *Soc Psychol Personal Sci* 2020, **11**:266–275, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1948550619845927>.
15. Zaki J, Bolger N, Ochsner K: **It takes two: the interpersonal nature of empathic accuracy.** *Psychol Sci* 2008, **19**:399–404, <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2008.02099.x>.
16. Itzchakov G, Reis HT, Weinstein N: **How to foster perceived partner responsiveness: high-quality listening is key.** *Social & Personality Psych* 2022, **16**, <https://doi.org/10.1111/spc3.12648>.  
Proposes a theoretical model linking high quality listening to perceived partner responsiveness.
17. Overall NC, Fletcher GJO, Simpson JA, Fillo J: **Attachment insecurity, biased perceptions of romantic partners' negative emotions, and hostile relationship behavior.** *J Pers Soc Psychol* 2015, **108**:730–749, <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0038987>.
18. Itzchakov G, Reis HT: **Perceived responsiveness increases tolerance of attitude ambivalence and enhances intentions to behave in an open-minded manner.** *Pers Soc Psychol Bull* 2021, **47**:468–485, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167220929218>.
19. Schimel J, Arndt J, Pyszczynski T, Greenberg J: **Being accepted for who we are: evidence that social validation of the intrinsic self reduces general defensiveness.** *J Pers Soc Psychol* 2001, **80**:35–52, <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.80.1.35>.
20. Lemay EP, Clark MS: **How the head liberates the heart: projection of communal responsiveness guides relationship promotion.** *J Pers Soc Psychol* 2008, **94**:647–671, <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.94.4.647>.
21. Cohen S, Schulz MS, Weiss E, Waldinger RJ: **Eye of the beholder: the individual and dyadic contributions of empathic accuracy and perceived empathic effort to relationship satisfaction.** *J Fam Psychol* 2012, **26**:236–245, <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0027488>.
22. Sanford K: **Communication during marital conflict: when couples alter their appraisal, they change their behavior.** *J Fam Psychol* 2006, **20**:256–265, <https://doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.20.2.256>.
23. Gordon AM, Tuskeviciute R, Chen S: **A multimethod investigation of depressive symptoms, perceived understanding, and relationship quality.** *Pers Relat* 2013, **20**:635–654, <https://doi.org/10.1111/pere.12005>.
24. Swann W, Pelham B: **Who wants out when the going gets good? Psychological investment and preference for self-verifying college roommates.** *Self Ident* 2002, **1**:219–233, <https://doi.org/10.1080/152988602760124856>.
25. Oishi S, Koo M, Akimoto S: **Culture, interpersonal perceptions, and happiness in social interactions.** *Pers Soc Psychol Bull* 2008, **34**:307–320, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167207311198>.
26. Rossignac-Milon M, Bolger N, Zee KS, Boothby EJ, Higgins ET: **Merged minds: generalized shared reality in dyadic relationships.** *J Pers Soc Psychol* 2021, **120**:882–911, <https://doi.org/10.1037/pspi0000266>.
27. Major BC, Le Nguyen KD, Lundberg KB, Fredrickson BL: **Well-being correlates of perceived positivity resonance: evidence from trait and episode-level assessments.** *Pers Soc Psychol Bull* 2018, **44**:1631–1647, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167218771324>.
28. Brown CL, Chen K-H, Wells JL, Otero MC, Connelly DE, Levenson RW, et al.: **Shared emotions in shared lives: moments of co-experienced affect, more than individually experienced affect, linked to relationship quality.** *Emotion* 2022, **22**:1387–1393, <https://doi.org/10.1037/emo0000939>.
29. Reis HT, Regan A, Lyubomirsky S: **Interpersonal chemistry: what is it, how does it emerge, and how does it operate?** *Perspect Psychol Sci* 2022, **17**:530–558, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1745691621994241>.

30. Winkelman P, Niedenthal P, Wielgosz J, Eelen J, Kavanagh LC: *Embodiment of cognition and emotion. APA handbook of personality and social psychology, Volume 1: Attitudes and social cognition*. Washington, DC, US: American Psychological Association; 2015:151–175, <https://doi.org/10.1037/14341-004>.
31. Pauly T, Michalowski VI, Drewelies J, Gerstorf D, Ashe MC, Madden KM, et al.: **Cortisol synchrony in older couples: daily socioemotional correlates and interpersonal differences.** *Psychosom Med* 2020, **82**:669–677, <https://doi.org/10.1097/PSY.0000000000000838>.
32. Hawkins MW, Carrère S, Gottman JM: **Marital sentiment override: does it influence couples' perceptions?** *J Marriage Fam* 2002, **64**: 193–201, <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2002.00193.x>.
33. Weinstein N, Huo A, Itzhakov G: **Parental listening when adolescents self-disclose: a preregistered experimental study.** *J Exp Child Psychol* 2021, **209**, 105178, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jecp.2021.105178>.
34. Behfar KJ, Cronin MA, McCarthy K: **Realizing the upside of venting: the role of the “challenger listener.”** *AMD* 2020, **6**: 609–630, <https://doi.org/10.5465/amd.2018.0066>.
35. Gordon AM, Chen S: **Do you get where I'm coming from?: perceived understanding buffers against the negative impact of conflict on relationship satisfaction.** *J Pers Soc Psychol* 2016, **110**:239–260, <https://doi.org/10.1037/pspi0000039>.  
Cross-sectional, daily diary, and laboratory studies show the buffering effects of feeling understood.
36. Barton AW, Futris TG, Nielsen RB: **Linking financial distress to marital quality: the intermediary roles of demand/withdraw and spousal gratitude expressions.** *Pers Relat* 2015, **22**: 536–549, <https://doi.org/10.1111/pere.12094>.
37. Barton AW, Jenkins AIC, Gong Q, Sutton NC, Beach SR: **The protective effects of perceived gratitude and expressed gratitude for relationship quality among African American couples.** *J Soc Pers Relat* 2023, **40**:1622–1644, <https://doi.org/10.1177/02654075221131288>.
38. Gordon AM, Cross E, Ascigil E, Balzarini R, Luerksen A, Muise A: **Feeling appreciated buffers against the negative effects of unequal division of household labor on relationship satisfaction.** *Psychol Sci* 2022, **33**:1313–1327, <https://doi.org/10.1177/09567976221081872>.  
Data from three different large samples show the buffering effects of feeling appreciated.
39. Park Y, Impett EA, MacDonald G, Lemay Jr EP: **Saying “thank you”: partners' expressions of gratitude protect relationship satisfaction and commitment from the harmful effects of attachment insecurity.** *J Pers Soc Psychol* 2019, **117**:773–806, <https://doi.org/10.1037/pspi0000178>.  
Provides evidence of the buffering effects of feeling appreciated
40. Murray SL: **Regulating relationship risk: partner responsiveness as a safety signal.** *Current Opinion in Psychology* 2023, **50**, 101582, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2023.101582>.
41. Park Y, Johnson MD, MacDonald G, Impett EA: **Perceiving gratitude from a romantic partner predicts decreases in attachment anxiety.** *Dev Psychol* 2019, **55**:2692.
42. Algoe SB: **Find, remind, and bind: the functions of gratitude in everyday relationships.** *Social and Personality Psychology Compass* 2012, **6**:455–469, <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1751-9004.2012.00439.x>.
43. Parkinson C, Kleinbaum AM, Wheatley T: **Similar neural responses predict friendship.** *Nat Commun* 2018, **9**:332, <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-017-02722-7>.
44. Li L, Huang X, Xiao J, Zheng Q, Shan X, He C, et al.: **Neural synchronization predicts marital satisfaction.** *Proc Natl Acad Sci USA* 2022, **119**, e2202515119, <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2202515119>.
45. Jolink TA, Algoe SB: **What happens in initial interactions forecasts relationship development: showcasing the role of social behavior.** *Soc Psychol Personal Sci* 2023, **194855062311534**, <https://doi.org/10.1177/19485506231153438>.
46. Kurtz LE, Algoe SB: **When sharing a laugh means sharing more: testing the role of shared laughter on short-term interpersonal consequences.** *J Nonverbal Behav* 2017, **41**: 45–65, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10919-016-0245-9>.
47. McNulty JK, Dugas A: **A dyadic perspective on gratitude sheds light on both its benefits and its costs: evidence that low gratitude acts as a “weak link.”** *J Fam Psychol* 2019, **33**: 876–881, <https://doi.org/10.1037/fam0000533>.
48. Park Y, Gordon A, Humberg S, Muise A, Impett EA: **Differing levels of gratitude between romantic partners: concurrent and longitudinal links with satisfaction and commitment in six dyadic datasets.** *Personal Sci* 2023, **4**, e10537, <https://doi.org/10.5964/ps.10537>.
49. Kluger AN, Malloy TE, Pery S, Itzhakov G, Castro DR, Lipetz L, et al.: **Dyadic listening in teams: social relations model.** *Appl Psychol* 2021, **70**:1045–1099, <https://doi.org/10.1111/apps.12263>.